Just a few decades earlier, the Golden Horde would have presented Timur with a formidable challenge. But now, the Golden Horde seemed poised for plucking. Plague had weakened both the Rus' cities and the Mongol government that oversaw them; and then, in 1359, a fight between two brothers of the khanship had spread into a khanate-wide struggle. In the years before Timur's arrival, pretenders all over the Horde—at one time, seven simultaneously—claimed to be the rightful khan. The man who eventually came out on top could claim descent from Genghis Khan's son Juchi. His name was Toktamish and he came, originally, from the Chagatai lands; and some years before, he had sworn a vassal's loyalty to Timur himself.[9]

He had claimed the khanship of the Golden Horde despite a massive rebellion by the Rus' princes, who had hoped to throw off the Mongol overlordship altogether. Faced with the defiance of Moscow, Riazan', and a handful of other Rus' cities, Toktamish descended on them with full Mongol ferocity, plundered their treasuries, burned their houses, and slaughtered their women and children. By the time Timur arrived at his borders, Toktamish had terrorized the Rus' back into submission.[10]

Now he turned to face his former master, refusing to surrender to Timur's demands for the proper obedience owed to him by his vassal.

The Rus' princes, called upon to fight *with* their oppressor against this newest arrival, chose to obey. Timur seemed the worse of the two choices: an "iniquitious, ferocious and terrible torturer and destroyer," the Russian chronicles call him. Backed by the Rus' princes, Toktamish met Timur's army in 1391, just east of the Volga river; and there he was badly defeated.

He retreated to the west, leaving the eastern part of the Horde territory in Timur's hands. During the next year, Timur fought his way through the Rus' cities as far as Elets. There, says the Russian chronicle of the invasion, he "captured the prince of Elets and tortured to death many people." Two hundred miles away from Moscow, he stopped, unwilling to push farther in the face of a devastatingly frigid Russian winter.[11]

He had rebellions to put down south of the Caspian Sea, and he had his eye on Baghdad, which he entered with little difficulty in August of 1393. He did not launch another major invasion of Toktamish's territory until 1394.

Once again the Rus' princes joined their Mongol overlord to fight off the Mongol threat. And once again, they were defeated. On the Terek river, in 1395, Toktamish fought against Timur for three entire days before he was forced to flee. He spent the rest of his life as a fugitive, mostly wandering through Siberia, trying to stay alive.

This time, the entire land of the Rus' lay open to Timur. He sacked the Golden Horde capital city of Sarai, on the Volga, and then spent eight months